Spade from John Brown's Body

By Stephen Vincent Benet

INTRODUCTION

Spade is a slave who escapes to freedom and characterizes traits of the common people that Benet so admires, people who suffered, fought, and died to bring about a new birth of American freedom. Benet treats them all with honor and respects the choices they made. Spade from John Brown's Body by Stephen Vincent Benet

The slave got away from Zachary's place that night.
He was a big fellow named Spade with one cropped ear.
He had splay feet and sometimes walked with a limp.
His back was scarred. He was black as a pine at night.
He'd tried to run away a couple of times
--That was how he got some of the marks you could tell him by--
But he'd been pretty quiet now for a year or so

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And they thought he had settled down.
When he got away
He meant to kill Zachary first but the signs weren't right.
He talked to the knife but the knife didn't sweat or heat,
So he just got away instead.
When he reached the woods
And was all alone, he was pretty scared for a while,
But he kept on going all night by the big soft stars,
Loping as fast as he could on his long splay feet
And when morning broke, he knew he was safe for a time.

He came out on a cleared place, then. He saw the red Sun spill over the trees.
He threw his pack
Down on the ground and started to laugh and laugh,

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"Spade, boy, Spade, you's lucky to git dis far.
You never managed to git dis far before,
De Lawd's sho'ly with you, Spade."

He ate and drank.

He drew a circle for Zachary's face in the ground
And spat in the circle. Then he thought of his woman.
"She's sho'ly a grievin' woman dis mawnin', Spade."
The thought made him sad at first, but he soon
cheered up.
"She'll do all right as soon as she's thu with grievin'.
Grievin' yaller gals always does all right.
Next time I'se gwine to git me a coal-black gal.
I'se tired of persimmon-skins.

I'se gwine to break loose.

De signs is right dis time. I'se gwine to be free,
Free in de Norf."

He saw himself in the North.

He had a stovepipe hat and a coal-black gal.

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He had a white-folks' house and a regular mule.
He worked for money and nobody ever owned him.
He got religion and dollars and lucky dice
And everybody he passed in the white folks' street
Said "Good mawnin', Mr. Spade--Mr. Spade, good
mawnin'."
He chuckled aloud. "Good mawnin', Mistuh Spade,
Gwine to be free, Mistuh Spade--yes, suh, Mistuh
Spade!"
For a lazy moment, he was already there--
Then he stiffened, nostrils flaring, at a slight sound.
It couldn't be dogs already.

"Jesus," he whispered,

"Sweet, lovin' Jesus, don't let 'em git me again,
Burn me up, but don't let 'em git me again,
Dey's gwine to cut me apart."

The rabbit ran past.

He stared at it for a moment with wild, round eyes,

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Started a yell of laughter--and choked it off.

"Dat ain't no nachul rabbit dere, Spade, boy.

Dat's a sign. Yes, suh. You better start makin'

tracks.

Take your foot in your hand, Mistuh Spade."

He swung the bundle

Up on his shoulders and slid along through the trees.

The bundle was light. He was going to be hungry soon

And the big splay feet would soon be bleeding and

sore,

But, as he went, he shook with uncanny chuckles.

"Good mawnin', Mr. Spade--glad to see you dis

mawnin'!

How's Mrs. Spade, Mr. Spade?"

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AWARD HISTORY

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